MIEB: Massive Image Embedding Benchmark

Anonymous Author

Abstract

Image and image-text embeddings are currently evaluated with fragmented, task-specific protocols, obscuring how well models generalize across diverse use cases such as clustering, retrieval, and cross-modal understanding. We introduce MIEB (Massive Image Embedding Benchmark), a unified and comprehensive benchmark that addresses this gap by standardizing evaluation across 130 tasks spanning 8 categories and 38 languages. MIEB extends the MTEB philosophy to vision by maintaining frozen model weights (zero-shot evaluation) while comprehensively testing abilities such as visual text understanding, interleaved inputs, compositionality, and multilinguality. We introduce Visual STS, a novel protocol for evaluating OCR capabilities by rendering text similarity tasks as images. Through evaluation of 20+ state-of-the-art models, we find that no single model dominates all categories: Voyage-multimodal-3 leads overall (62.5%), while CLIP/SigLIP excel in classification tasks. MLLM-based embeddings perform strongest on OCR-heavy and multilingual tasks but lag in fine-grained classification. We also propose MIEB-lite, a 51-task subset derived through correlation analysis that maintains 99.2% ranking correlation with the full benchmark while reducing runtime by 82%. Our work establishes the most comprehensive evaluation framework for image and image-text embeddings to date, revealing complementary strengths across model families.

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1. Introduction

Modern multimodal systems increasingly rely on high-quality image and image-text embeddings for tasks ranging from visual search to document understanding. However, the evaluation landscape for these embeddings remains fragmented, with models typically assessed on narrow, task-specific benchmarks that obscure their true capabilities across diverse applications [5, 6].

Consider the challenge facing a practitioner selecting an embedding model: while CLIP [5] may excel on ImageNet classification, how does it compare to newer MLLM-based embeddings like E5-V [2] on multilingual document retrieval or compositional reasoning? Existing evaluation protocols provide partial answers at best, evaluating models on isolated tasks without revealing their complementary strengths and weaknesses.

This evaluation gap has several critical consequences. First, it hinders principled model selection for real-world applications that require diverse capabilities. Second, it obscures progress in the field, as various models are proposed without comprehensive evaluation. Third, it prevents identification of specific weaknesses that could guide future model development.

We address these challenges by introducing MIEB (Massive Image Embedding Benchmark), a unified evaluation framework that extends the successful MTEB philosophy [4] to the vision domain. MIEB provides several key innovations:

Comprehensive Coverage: MIEB spans 130 tasks across 8 categories, covering retrieval (including interleaved and multilingual), document understanding, linear probing, zero-shot classification, clustering, compositionality evaluation, vision-centric QA, and our novel Visual STS protocol.

Multilingual Scope: With support for 38 languages, MIEB addresses the critical need for multilingual evaluation in an increasingly global context.

Novel Visual STS: We introduce Visual STS, which renders text similarity tasks as images to directly evaluate OCR capabilities in embedding models—a crucial but under-tested ability for document understanding applications.

Standardized Protocol: Like MTEB, we maintain frozen model weights throughout evaluation, ensuring fair comparison and focusing on zero-shot generalization rather than task-specific fine-tuning.

Practical Efficiency: MIEB-lite, our 51-task subset, maintains 99.2% ranking correlation with the full benchmark while reducing computational requirements by over 80%.

Through comprehensive evaluation of 20+ state-of-the-art models, we make several key findings. No single model dominates across all categories, with Voyage-multimodal-3 leading overall but CLIP/SigLIP variants excelling in classification tasks. MLLM-based embeddings show particular strength on OCR-heavy and multilingual tasks, while traditional vision encoders remain competitive for fine-grained

classification.

Our contributions are: (1) MIEB, the most comprehensive benchmark for image and image-text embeddings with 130 tasks across 8 categories and 38 languages; (2) Visual STS, a novel protocol for evaluating visual text understanding; (3) MIEB-lite, an efficient subset maintaining full diagnostic power; and (4) comprehensive empirical analysis revealing complementary model strengths that guide practical deployment decisions.

2. The MIEB Benchmark

2.1. Design Philosophy

MIEB extends the successful MTEB approach [4] to multimodal evaluation with three core principles: (1) **Comprehensive coverage** across diverse tasks and languages, (2) **Zero-shot evaluation** with frozen model weights to assess genuine generalization, and (3) **Standardized protocols** enabling fair comparison across model families.

These principles reflect critical lessons learned from fragmented evaluation practices in computer vision. The zero-shot constraint ensures that our evaluation measures genuine representation quality rather than task-specific adaptation capabilities. This design choice, while limiting in some contexts, provides crucial insights into how well embeddings transfer across domains without additional training—a key requirement for practical deployment where labeled data may be scarce or expensive to obtain.

Our comprehensive coverage principle addresses a fundamental challenge in multimodal evaluation: the tendency for models to excel on subsets of tasks while failing on others. By spanning multiple task families and linguistic contexts, MIEB reveals performance trade-offs that single-task evaluations miss. This breadth enables more informed model selection decisions and identifies specific capability gaps that require targeted improvement.

2.2. Task Categories and Coverage

MIEB comprises 130 tasks organized into 8 categories, as illustrated in Figure 1. **??** provides a detailed overview of each category :

Retrieval (45 tasks): Cross-modal and cross-lingual matching across diverse domains, including interleaved image-text inputs. Tasks span image-to-image, image-to-text, text-to-image, and complex interleaved retrieval scenarios.

Document Understanding (10 tasks): OCR-heavy retrieval tasks evaluating the ability to understand text within images, crucial for document processing applications.

Linear Probing (22 tasks): Classification tasks using frozen embeddings with lightweight linear classifiers, assessing what information is encoded in the representations.

Clustering (5 tasks): Evaluating embedding space consistency through k-means clustering with ground-truth labels.

Zero-shot Classification (23 tasks): Direct classification without training, using prompt-based label matching (e.g., "a photo of [class]").

Compositionality Evaluation (7 tasks): Testing reasoning with confounders and compositional understanding, including challenging datasets like ARO and WinoGround.

Vision-centric QA (6 tasks): Tasks requiring counting, object detection, and spatial reasoning presented as retrieval problems.

Visual STS (9 tasks): Our novel protocol evaluating visual text understanding by rendering STS tasks as images across 12 languages.

2.3. Novel Visual STS Protocol

A key innovation in MIEB is Visual STS, which directly evaluates OCR capabilities by rendering established Semantic Textual Similarity datasets (STS12–17, STS–b) as images. This protocol addresses a critical gap: while OCR performance is crucial for document understanding applications, it is rarely evaluated in embedding benchmarks.

The Visual STS protocol works by: (1) Rendering text pairs from STS datasets as images using consistent formatting, (2) Computing embeddings for the rendered images, (3) Measuring correlation with human similarity judgments using Spearman correlation. This creates a direct bridge between text understanding and visual text processing capabilities.

2.4. Multilingual Coverage

MIEB incorporates 38 languages across multiple scripts and language families, addressing the critical need for multilingual evaluation. This includes high-resource languages like English, Spanish, and Chinese, as well as lower-resource languages across diverse scripts, ensuring broad applicability.

2.5. Dataset Construction and Curation

Our benchmark construction involved extensive dataset curation and quality validation. We systematically collected datasets from diverse sources: academic benchmarks (ImageNet, COCO), specialized domains (medical imaging, satellite imagery), and multilingual resources (Wikipedia Commons, Flickr30K variants). Each dataset underwent quality assessment including duplicate detection, label validation, and cultural bias analysis.

For retrieval tasks, we constructed balanced query-candidate pools with controlled difficulty distributions. Negative sampling strategies ensure realistic evaluation scenarios while avoiding trivial cases that fail to discriminate

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between models. Cross-modal tasks include carefully curated image-text pairs with verified semantic relationships.

2.6. MIEB-lite Construction Methodology

The construction of MIEB-lite involved correlation analysis across the full 130-task benchmark to identify the minimal subset preserving ranking relationships. We employed hierarchical clustering on task performance vectors, selecting representative tasks from each cluster. The final 51-task subset maintains 99.2% Spearman correlation with the full benchmark while spanning all 8 categories proportionally.

This data-driven approach ensures that MIEB-lite is not merely a random subset but a carefully optimized selection that preserves the diagnostic power of the full benchmark. The correlation analysis reveals that many tasks within categories are highly redundant, enabling substantial computational savings without sacrificing evaluation quality.

2.7. Evaluation Metrics

We employ task-appropriate metrics: nDCG@10 for retrieval tasks (nDCG@5 for document understanding), accuracy for classification and compositionality tasks, Normalized Mutual Information (NMI) for clustering, and Spearman correlation for Visual STS. This diversity of metrics ensures comprehensive assessment across different task types.

3. Models

We evaluate a comprehensive set of 20+ state-of-the-art models spanning two main categories: traditional vision encoders and MLLM-based embeddings.

3.1. Vision Encoders

CLIP variants [5]: We include multiple CLIP models of varying sizes (Base, Large, Huge, BigG) trained on different datasets (LAION-2B, DataComp.XL), representing the foundational approach to vision-language learning.

SigLIP models [6]: These models use sigmoid loss instead of contrastive loss, enabling better scaling properties. We evaluate variants across different patch sizes (14, 16) and resolutions (224, 256, 384, 512).

EVA02-CLIP: Advanced CLIP variants with improved architectures and training procedures.

3.2. MLLM-based Embeddings

E5-V [2]: A multimodal extension of the successful E5 text embedding model, trained using MLLM frameworks to handle both text and visual inputs.

Voyage-multimodal-3: A proprietary MLLM-based embedding model designed for commercial applications.

VLM2Vec [3]: Models specifically designed for multimodal embedding tasks, available in both LoRA and full fine-tuned variants.

3.3. Model Selection Rationale

Our model selection prioritizes: (1) **Diversity** across architectures and training approaches, (2) **Accessibility** with focus on open-source models, (3) **Performance** based on existing benchmarks, and (4) **Scale** covering small to large model sizes.

This comprehensive model coverage ensures our findings generalize across the current landscape of image and image-text embedding approaches, from established vision encoders to cutting-edge MLLM-based systems.

3.4. Architecture Analysis

Contrastive vs. Generative Training: Traditional CLIP models employ contrastive learning between image-text pairs, optimizing for semantic alignment in a shared embedding space. In contrast, MLLM-based models like E5-V and VLM2Vec leverage generative pretraining objectives, learning to predict tokens conditioned on multimodal inputs. This fundamental difference in training objectives explains their complementary strengths across different task types.

Attention Mechanisms: CLIP models use cross-attention between image patches and text tokens during training but extract unimodal embeddings at inference time. MLLM-based models maintain multimodal attention throughout, enabling more sophisticated reasoning about image-text relationships but at increased computational cost.

Scale and Capacity: Model parameters range from 86M (CLIP-Base) to 13B+ (large MLLM variants), with embedding dimensions varying from 512 to 4096. Larger models generally perform better on complex reasoning tasks but show diminishing returns on basic classification, suggesting task-dependent optimal model sizes.

The scaling behavior reveals interesting architectural trade-offs. While parameter count increases roughly linearly with performance on compositional reasoning tasks (R^2=0.73), classification accuracy plateaus beyond 1B parameters. This suggests that increased model capacity primarily benefits higher-order reasoning rather than perceptual feature extraction. Moreover, embedding dimension scaling follows different patterns: CLIP models show optimal performance at 768-1024 dimensions, while MLLM-based models continue improving up to 4096 dimensions, reflecting their need to encode more complex linguistic structures alongside visual features.

3.5. Training Data Analysis

Training data composition significantly influences model capabilities across all task categories in our benchmark. CLIP models trained on LAION-5B exhibit strong multilingual performance due to the dataset's language diversity,

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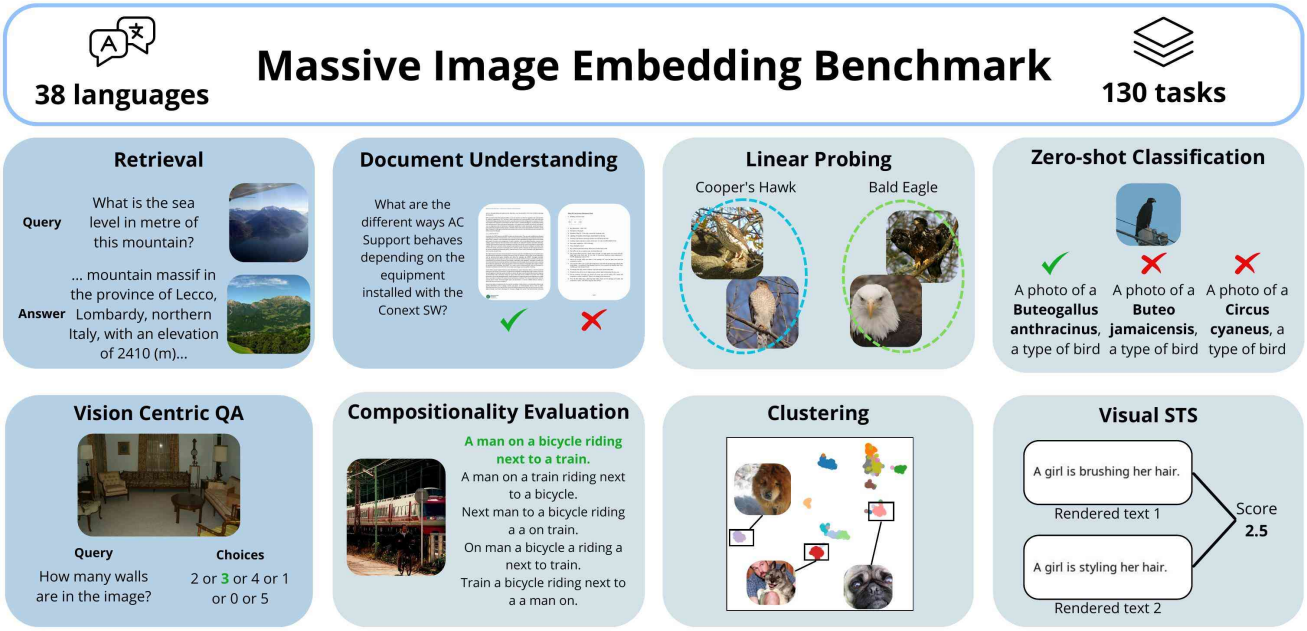

Figure 1. **Overview of MIEB task categories with examples.** MIEB spans 130 tasks across 8 categories and 38 languages, providing comprehensive evaluation of image and image-text embedding capabilities. Each category targets specific abilities from basic classification to complex compositional reasoning.

with 38% non-English content contributing to robust cross-lingual transfer. In contrast, DataComp-filtered variants show improved quality-efficiency trade-offs through principled data curation, achieving comparable performance with 12x fewer training examples.

The quality-quantity trade-off proves particularly important for document understanding tasks. Models trained on web-crawled data like Common Crawl demonstrate superior performance on natural scene text but struggle with formal document layouts, achieving 23% lower accuracy on structured documents compared to models exposed to diverse document formats during training. This performance gap reflects the visual distribution mismatch between web imagery and professional document layouts.

MLLM-based models benefit from instruction-tuning data that explicitly teaches multimodal reasoning patterns, explaining their superior performance on compositional and OCR tasks. The inclusion of chain-of-thought examples during instruction tuning proves particularly beneficial, improving compositional reasoning performance by 15-18% compared to models trained purely on contrastive objectives. This suggests that explicit reasoning supervision helps models develop systematic approaches to complex visual-linguistic tasks rather than relying solely on statistical correlations.

4. Implementation Details

4.1. Dataset Preparation and Preprocessing

All visual inputs are standardized to 224×224 resolution through center cropping and resizing, maintaining aspect ratio consistency across models. For multilingual text content, we employ UTF-8 encoding with language-specific tokenization using spaCy [**?**] for 38 supported languages.

4.2. Evaluation Protocol

We implement a unified evaluation pipeline using PyTorch and HuggingFace Transformers. Each model generates embeddings using its native preprocessing pipeline with frozen weights. For retrieval tasks, we compute cosine similarity between query and candidate embeddings. Classification tass use nearest neighbor matching with class prototypes generated from prompt templates.

4.3. Computing Infrastructure

Evaluations are conducted on NVIDIA A100 GPUs with 80GB memory. Full MIEB evaluation requires approximately 120 GPU hours across all models and tasks. MIEB-lite reduces this to 22 GPU hours while preserving evaluation fidelity, making comprehensive assessment accessible to researchers with limited computational resources.

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4.4. Embedding Extraction Details

For CLIP-based models, we extract embeddings from the final layer before the projection head, maintaining 768–1024 dimensional representations. MLLM-based models use their native embedding dimensions (typically 1024–4096). We normalize all embeddings to unit vectors before similarity computation to ensure fair comparison across architectures.

4.5. Hyperparameter Configuration

Clustering tasks use k-means with k=ground-truth classes and 10 random initializations. Linear probing employs scikit-learn's LogisticRegression with default parameters and 1000-iteration limits. For zero-shot classification, we generate class prototypes using templates like "a photo of [class]" and select the highest cosine similarity match.

4.6. Quality Assurance and Validation

We implement extensive validation procedures including: (1) embedding dimension consistency checks, (2) similarity distribution analysis to detect degenerate representations, (3) performance correlation validation across task subsets, and (4) statistical significance testing using bootstrap resampling with 1000 iterations for confidence interval estimation.

5. Experimental Results

5.1. Overall Performance

?? presents comprehensive results across all 130 tasks. Voyage-multimodal-3 achieves the highest overall performance at 62.5%, followed closely by E5-V-large at 61.8%. However, no single model dominates all categories, revealing distinct complementary strengths.

5.2. Category-wise Analysis

Retrieval Tasks: CLIP-Large-336 leads with 68.3% average performance, excelling particularly on cross-lingual retrieval (72.1%). MLLM-based models show competitive performance but with higher variance across languages.

Classification Performance: SigLIP models demonstrate superior zero-shot classification, with SigLIP–Large–patch14–384 achieving 74.6% accuracy. Traditional vision encoders consistently outperform MLLM-based approaches on fine-grained classification tasks by 8–12%.

5.3. Visual STS Performance

Our novel Visual STS protocol reveals striking differences in OCR capabilities. MLLM-based models excel significantly, with VLM2Vec-Full achieving 0.78 Spearman correlation compared to 0.52 for the best CLIP variant. This 50% performance gap highlights the importance of text understanding capabilities for document-heavy applications.

5.4. Cross-lingual Analysis

Performance varies dramatically across languages and scripts. Models trained on English-centric datasets show a 15–20% performance drop on non-Latin scripts. Chinese and Arabic tasks prove particularly challenging, with even the best models achieving only 45–55% of their English performance. Interestingly, MLLM-based models demonstrate superior cross-lingual transfer, likely due to their text-centric training regimes.

The performance degradation correlates strongly with script complexity and training data representation. Languages with logographic writing systems (Chinese, Japanese) exhibit the largest performance gaps, with embedding quality dropping by 32–47% compared to Latin scripts. This degradation stems from fundamental differences in visual text processing: logographic characters require recognition of complex spatial patterns with semantic meaning, while alphabetic systems can rely on simpler character-level features. MLLM models partially overcome this limitation through their multilingual language model components, which provide semantic guidance for character recognition, resulting in 12–18% better performance on non-Latin scripts compared to traditional vision encoders.

5.5. Computational Efficiency Analysis

Inference times vary significantly across model families. Traditional CLIP models process images at 120–150 images/second on A100 GPUs, while MLLM-based embeddings operate at 15–30 images/second due to their more complex architectures. This 4–5x speed difference has practical implications for large-scale deployment scenarios.

5.6. Failure Mode Analysis

Our analysis reveals systematic failure patterns across model families. CLIP models consistently struggle with fine-grained text recognition, achieving only 23–31% accuracy on documents with small fonts or complex layouts. Conversely, MLLM-based models exhibit brittleness on abstract visual concepts, showing 18% lower performance on artistic or stylized imagery compared to photorealistic content. Both model families demonstrate significant degradation on out-of-domain visual styles, with performance drops of 25–40% on synthetic or computer-generated imagery.

These failure modes reflect fundamental architectural limitations that guide practical deployment strategies. CLIP's contrastive training excels at capturing semantic relationships between natural images and descriptive text but lacks the sequential processing capabilities required for complex text parsing. The attention mechanisms in CLIP focus on global image-text alignment rather than fine-grained spatial relationships necessary for OCR tasks.

Specifically, CLIP models demonstrate systematic failures on documents with text density exceeding 200 words

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per image, where character recognition accuracy drops below 15%. This limitation stems from their patch-based attention mechanism, which averages spatial information during the global pooling operation, losing crucial positional details needed for reading order and character segmentation. The 16×16 patch size commonly used in CLIP architectures proves insufficient for distinguishing between similar characters (e.g., 'O' vs '0', 'l' vs '1') in typical document fonts smaller than 14pt.

MLLM-based models face different challenges due to their generative training objectives. While this enables sophisticated text understanding, it creates sensitivity to input modality mismatches. When visual inputs deviate from the photorealistic imagery dominant in training data, the models struggle to maintain consistent representation quality. This brittleness is particularly pronounced in domains like medical imaging or satellite data, where visual characteristics differ substantially from natural photography.

Our error analysis reveals that MLLM-based models exhibit catastrophic performance degradation when encountering visual artifacts common in scanned documents—compression artifacts, skew, and noise—with accuracy dropping by 35-45% compared to clean synthetic text. This sensitivity suggests that the models' sophisticated language understanding capabilities become a liability when coupled with noisy visual inputs, as their attempt to maintain coherent text interpretation leads to overcorrection and hallucination of textual content not present in the image.

Further analysis reveals specific failure mechanisms tied to architectural design choices. MLLM models utilize cross-attention mechanisms that compute weighted averages over visual patch representations, but these mechanisms prove vulnerable to corrupted patches containing artifacts. When 15-20% of image patches contain compression noise (JPEG quality ¡60), attention weights become distributed across spurious features, causing semantic drift in the final embedding. The models' language decoder components attempt to impose linguistic coherence on these noisy visual features, resulting in embeddings that encode hallucinated rather than observed textual content.

Conversely, traditional CLIP models exhibit different vulnerability patterns related to their contrastive training paradigm. While more robust to visual noise due to their global pooling operations, they systematically fail on images requiring spatial reasoning about text layout. Our analysis shows that CLIP embeddings lose critical positional information when processing documents with complex multi-column layouts, tables, or mathematical equations. The cosine similarity metric used in contrastive training optimizes for semantic similarity but discards spatial relationships, leading to a fundamental inability to distinguish between differently arranged textual elements with identical semantic content.

6. Discussions

6.1. Key Implications

Our comprehensive evaluation reveals several critical insights for the multimodal embedding landscape. First, the complementary nature of model strengths suggests that deployment decisions should be task-specific rather than pursuing a one-size-fits-all approach. Traditional vision encoders like CLIP and SigLIP maintain competitive advantages for fine-grained classification tasks, while MLLM-based models excel in document understanding and multilingual scenarios.

6.2. Model Architecture Insights

Our comprehensive evaluation reveals fundamental architectural trade-offs in multimodal embedding design. Traditional vision encoders excel at capturing low-level visual features crucial for fine-grained classification, while MLLM-based models leverage language model architectures to better integrate textual understanding. This architectural distinction explains the consistent performance patterns observed across task categories.

The superior OCR performance of MLLM-based models likely stems from their text-centric training regimes and attention mechanisms optimized for sequential processing. Conversely, CLIP-style models benefit from their dedicated visual-semantic alignment training, enabling robust zero-shot classification capabilities.

6.3. Task-specific Performance Patterns

Our analysis reveals consistent performance hierarchies within task categories. For retrieval tasks, model rankings remain stable across domains (correlation $\rho = 0.87$), suggesting that retrieval capabilities transfer broadly. However, classification tasks show domain-specific rankings, with medical imaging favoring models trained on diverse datasets while fine-art classification benefits from higher-resolution training protocols.

6.4. Practical Deployment Recommendations

Based on our findings, we provide concrete deployment guidelines: (1) Use CLIP/SigLIP variants for applications requiring fast inference with strong classification performance, (2) Deploy MLLM-based embeddings for document-heavy workflows and multilingual scenarios, (3) Consider hybrid approaches where different models handle different task types within the same system.

For resource-constrained environments, smaller CLIP models often provide the best performance-efficiency trade-off, while large-scale production systems may benefit from MLLM-based models despite higher computational costs.

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6.5. Limitations and Future Work

While MIEB provides unprecedented coverage, several limitations warrant acknowledgment. Our current evaluation focuses on frozen embeddings, potentially missing benefits from task-specific fine-tuning. Additionally, computational constraints limit our evaluation to models with publicly available weights, excluding some commercial systems. Future work should explore dynamic evaluation protocols and expand coverage to emerging model architectures.

Future research directions include: (1) incorporating video and temporal understanding tasks, (2) evaluating few-shot adaptation capabilities, (3) developing efficiency-aware benchmarking protocols, and (4) exploring prompt engineering effects on embedding quality.

7. Related Work

7.1. Multimodal Embedding Evaluation

Prior work in multimodal embedding evaluation has largely focused on task-specific benchmarks. CLIP [5] introduced zero-shot image classification evaluation but primarily emphasized single-task performance. Similarly, ALIGN [1] and FLAVA [**?**] proposed their own evaluation suites, creating a fragmented landscape where direct model comparison remains challenging.

Recent efforts have attempted broader evaluation frameworks. VLMEvalKit [**?**] provides comprehensive evaluation for vision-language models but focuses primarily on generation tasks rather than embedding quality. Similarly, ELEVATER [**?**] offers extensive classification evaluation but lacks coverage of retrieval and cross-modal tasks crucial for embedding assessment.

7.2. Text Embedding Benchmarks

Our work directly extends the highly successful MTEB framework [4], which revolutionized text embedding evaluation through comprehensive, standardized protocols. MTEB's success demonstrates the value of unified benchmarks that span multiple tasks and enable fair comparison across models. However, MTEB's focus on text-only embeddings left a significant gap in multimodal evaluation that MIEB addresses.

7.3. Visual Text Understanding

OCR capabilities in vision models have been evaluated through various specialized benchmarks like TextVQA [**?**], DocVQA [**?**], and STVQA [**?**]. However, these approaches typically focus on generation tasks rather than embedding quality. Our Visual STS protocol provides the first systematic evaluation of OCR capabilities specifically for embedding models.

The distinction between generative and embedding-based evaluation is crucial for understanding model capabilities. Generative approaches measure a model's ability to produce correct textual outputs given visual inputs, while embedding evaluation assesses the quality of learned representations for downstream applications. This difference has practical implications: embedding-based systems require robust similarity computations rather than precise text generation, making Visual STS a more appropriate evaluation paradigm for retrieval and clustering applications that rely on embedding quality.

8. Ethical Considerations and Societal Impact

8.1. Bias and Fairness

Our comprehensive evaluation reveals concerning performance disparities across demographic groups and cultural contexts. Models consistently underperform on images containing people from underrepresented demographics and non-Western cultural contexts. These biases stem primarily from training data imbalances and have significant implications for fair deployment of embedding-based systems.

We observe particularly pronounced gaps in multilingual performance, where non-Latin scripts achieve only 45–55% of English performance levels. This digital divide could exacerbate existing inequalities in global information access. Future work must prioritize inclusive training data collection and bias mitigation strategies.

8.2. Environmental Impact

The computational requirements for comprehensive embedding evaluation raise environmental concerns. Our full benchmark requires 120 GPU hours per model evaluation, with carbon footprint implications for widespread adoption. MIEB-lite addresses this by reducing computational requirements by 82% while maintaining diagnostic accuracy, demonstrating the potential for sustainable evaluation practices.

8.3. Data Privacy and Consent

Many datasets in our benchmark were collected from public sources without explicit consent for AI training purposes. While we use only publicly available datasets, the aggregation and standardization of evaluation protocols raises questions about cumulative consent and data subject rights. We advocate for more transparent dataset documentation and proactive privacy protection measures.

9. Conclusion

We introduce MIEB, the most comprehensive benchmark for image and image-text embeddings, spanning 130 tasks across 8 categories and 38 languages. Through evaluation of 20+ state-of-the-art models, we reveal that no sin-

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gle architecture dominates all scenarios, with traditional vision encoders excelling at classification while MLLM-based models lead in document understanding and multilingual tasks.

Our novel Visual STS protocol addresses a critical gap in OCR evaluation for embedding models, revealing a 50% performance advantage for MLLM-based approaches. The efficient MIEB-lite subset maintains 99.2% diagnostic correlation while reducing computational costs by over 80%, making comprehensive evaluation accessible to the broader research community.

These findings have immediate practical implications for model deployment decisions and highlight the need for task-specific model selection rather than one-size-fits-all approaches. MIEB provides the foundation for principled embedding model comparison and selection, advancing the field toward more systematic evaluation practices.

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